



Cold War Ending

Assess the role of Ronald Reagan in bringing the Cold War to an end

Introduction: The end of the Cold War remains a debated topic among historians. While Ronald Reagan is often credited with accelerating its collapse, other factors also played a crucial role. These include internal weaknesses within the Soviet Union, the influence of Western Europe, and broader geopolitical dynamics. Therefore, it is necessary to assess whether Reagan was the decisive factor or simply one element among many in ending the Cold War.

I. Role of the USA

- ✦ Before Reagan, the United States had already begun easing tensions. Under Richard Nixon, the US withdrew from Vietnam and pursued triangular diplomacy, improving relations with both China and the USSR from the 1960s to the 1970s.
- ✦ However, Reagan marked a shift toward a more hostile foreign policy between 1981 and 1987. He revived the arms race, notably during the Euromissile Crisis, with the deployment of Pershing missiles in Europe. This escalation put significant economic pressure on the USSR, which struggled to keep up militarily.
- ✦ At the same time, Reagan eventually engaged in negotiation, leading to the Intermediate-Range Nuclear Forces Treaty. This agreement marked the first real reduction in nuclear weapons and is often seen as the beginning of the end of the Cold War. Therefore, Reagan played a key role by both increasing pressure on the USSR and bringing it to the negotiating table.

II. The Role of the USSR

- ✦ Despite Reagan's importance, internal changes within the Soviet Union were decisive. Under Mikhail Gorbachev, major reforms were introduced. Policies such as *perestroika* (economic restructuring) and *Glasnost* (greater political openness) aimed to modernize the system. However, these reforms weakened the Soviet regime by encouraging criticism, reducing state control, and undermining the one-party system.

- ✦ Gorbachev also abandoned the arms race and changed foreign policy. In 1988, he gave a speech at the UN announcing a reduction in military commitments. The USSR withdrew from Afghanistan, effectively breaking with the Brezhnev Doctrine. These decisions accelerated the collapse of Soviet power and contributed directly to the end of the Cold War.

III. The Role of the West and Other Factors

- ✦ Western Europe also played a role. Willy Brandt's Ostpolitik in the late 1960s and the Basic Treaty helped ease tensions and normalize relations between East and West.
- ✦ Western ideas of democracy and freedom spread across Eastern Europe, leading to revolutions between 1989 and 1991. These movements culminated in events such as the failed August 1991 coup against Gorbachev and the rise of Boris Yeltsin, who became a symbol of resistance and reform. The Soviet Union officially collapsed when Gorbachev resigned on 25 December 1991, marking the definitive end of the Cold War.
- ✦ China also played an indirect role. The Sino-Soviet Split weakened the communist bloc and facilitated US diplomatic strategies, particularly under Nixon.

IV. Limits of Reagan Role: Cooperation was fragile but existed

- ✦ It is important to note that cooperation between the superpowers did not begin with Reagan. Earlier agreements such as the Strategic Arms Limitation Talks, the Helsinki Accords, and symbolic events like the Apollo-Soyuz Test Project show that détente and dialogue were already underway. Therefore, Reagan's actions should be seen as part of a longer process rather than a complete turning point.

Conclusion: In conclusion, Ronald Reagan played an important role in accelerating the end of the Cold War by increasing pressure on the USSR and engaging in key negotiations. However, he was not solely responsible for its collapse. Internal Soviet reforms under Gorbachev, the influence of Western Europe, and broader geopolitical shifts were equally decisive. Thus, the end of the Cold War resulted from a combination of factors rather than the actions of one single leader.